Buildiwick Business Database — Developer Brief

The Problem

Right now our project costs live in three places that do not talk to each other: a WhatsApp group where site supervisors text in expenses, a few Excel workbooks, and people's memory. We want to account for every shilling know what each project cost, whether it was profitable, and what clients have paid versus what is still owed.

We have tried some few online options and they did not work for us. Cost codes did not match our settings, item descriptions got read as cost types, units like EA/KGS/LS needed manual mapping every time, imported costs sometimes showed as TSh 0.00, and one file came in with unreadable characters. It also assumed every purchase was already predicted in a budget which doesn't match how we actually buy materials. We are not ruling options out there, but we want a simple, disciplined habit of recording actual income and expenses first, in something plainer.

What We Need Tracked

Every project's income and expenses, sorted into four categories:

1. **Materials** recorded item by item: project, supplier, date, invoice/receipt number, description, quantity, unit, unit cost, total (quantity × unit cost), and a photo of the receipt
2. **Labour & Subcontracts** the agreed contract value, advances and instalments paid, and the running balance (e.g. a fundi agreement of TSh 1,900,000, with a TSh 205,000 advance leaving TSh 1,695,000 outstanding)
3. **Logistics & Equipment** — transport, delivery, loading/offloading, equipment hire
4. **Preliminaries & Site Overheads** — site cleaning, general site costs

On top of that: client invoices and payments (what's been invoiced, what's been paid, what's outstanding), cash flow (money in vs. money out), and profitability per project once it closes. We want to keep the item-level detail even when we are also looking at broader category totals both views matter.

How the Data Should Be Structured

This needs to be properly linked tables, not one flat sheet one supplier invoice can have several line items, one labour agreement can have several instalments, one client invoice can have several payments, and everything ties back to a project. Roughly:

Projects · Clients · Vendors/Suppliers · Workers/Fundis/Subcontractors · Expense line items · Labour/subcontract agreements and their payments · Client invoices and receipts · Material/item catalogue (for historical pricing) · Users and roles · Attachments (receipts, photos)

We don't want one rigid cost breakdown forced onto every project — a small specialised job and a large residential build won't have the same structure.

Who Uses It, and What They Can See

Role	Can see / do
Admin/Directors	Everything — all projects, costs, profit, cash flow, dashboards, user management
Accounts/Invoicing	Client invoices and receipts, supplier bills, expense payments
Estimator/QS	Historical prices and rates for estimating — not company cash, profit or client payments
Project Manager	Their assigned projects; can review and approve expenses
Site Operator	Can enter expenses only — no dashboard, no quoted amounts, no profit, no cash flow, no client invoices

Privacy matters here hiding spreadsheet tabs isn't enough, since anyone with the file can still find them. Site staff should submit through a form, not get access to the underlying records.

Our Approach

Start simple: get disciplined at recording actual income and expenses before adding anything else.

For this first version, please leave out: budgeting and estimating, JobTread-style budget preparation, and markup calculations inside the day-to-day system. Dashboards and reports (an all-projects view of invoiced/paid/pending, spend by category, profitability) come after the data-entry side is working properly — not before.

What We Need From You

1. Design the linked table structure above projects, clients, suppliers, labour agreements, expenses, invoices
2. Build a simple online form for entering income and expenses, with the right fields per category, that posts straight into the right tables
3. Set up role-based access so site staff only see what they should